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How Can Anyone Oppose Internet Sales Tax?

DAVID COURSEY HAS been writing for over two decades on hardware and software. Here, he wonders why people in the US are opposing the proposed Internet Sales Tax

Hot news: Sales taxes are going to be collected on purchases made over the Internet. It will take a new federal law and a clearinghouse arrangement to handle distribution of the revenue, but it's going to happen. That's not a prediction, that's a promise. And it will happen within five years, too.

I am not sure why people oppose this. Not collecting these taxes saves people a few bucks, but it's at the expense of community services and disadvantages local merchants.

Sure, I like buying stuff "tax-free" over the Internet, but I like my local police and schools more. I also like my local merchants, who hire local folks, some of whom are getting hammered by customers who shop locally and then buy over the Internet and out-of-state.

Frankly, the only reason I can imagine for not already collecting sales tax on Internet purchases is a pesky Supreme Court ruling that linked tax collection to physical location. With the Internet and rapid shipping of goods purchased there, location isn't what it used to be.

OK, there's the other reason: We need a mechanism that makes it easy to collect sales tax and send it to the

50 states without the merchant having to file for 50 state tax permits, write 50 checks, file 50 reports, etc.

I see no reason why accounting software couldn't create an electronic transaction report that could be attached to an electronic payment and sent to a clearing house. There, the file would be read and the taxes properly divided.

As for collecting the proper tax, downloading tax tables is not a very big deal. You might occasionally have to ask a shopper what county they live in, or something similar.

What might slow it down, however, is the need for some new tax regulations in the states after Congress gives it OK.

Chris Nolan's readers notwithstanding, I really don't understand how anyone could oppose this. Well, anyone who doesn't think that all taxes are bad. To those people, any kink in the taxing system that lets money slide seems like a good thing.

Fairness is an important issue here. Why should brick-and-mortar vendors, who contribute far more to their communities than just tax revenue, be discriminated against?

I think a fair case could be made that Internet vendors should pay more taxes than those selling from retail storefronts.

It is very important to make these payments as transparent to merchants as possible. But, beyond the need for a technological solution, I can see no reason why someone interested in tax fairness wouldn't support collecting sales tax on all Internet transactions.

Sales taxes are bread-and-butter revenue for local government. They are what helps pay for the community services we use every day. If the federal government feels for some reason that Internet businesses need a break, they should implement it through the IRS code, though I see no need. Internet businesses never were on life-support.

Local governments and brick-and-mortar business deserve a break, too.

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Google Earth: Officially All Over the Map

ADDRESSING ISSUES RELATED to personal technology and monitoring the changes and advances taking place in today's fast-changing wired world are just some of the things Rob Pegoraro has been writing about. In this column for The Washington Post, he takes on the newly-launched Google Earth and gives it a thumbs up.

You can't accuse Google of thinking small. Having sewn up, upended or merely rejuvenated the markets for Web searching, Web-mail services, digital photography and file searching, it's now set its sights on something slightly larger: the Earth.

Google Earth takes the Google Maps service into multiple dimensions. Instead of presenting top-down views of maps or satellite photos, this software wraps those high-resolution satellite photos on a three-dimensional model of our planet's land surface that recreates every molehill and mountain, then lets you eyeball the scenery from any angle you wish.

By selecting options from an extensive menu of "layers," you

can then add more details. The program starts you off with a view of the world as a sphere in space. The first cue that you're looking at a different sort of atlas comes when you type in a search for a place: Google Earth sends you hurtling toward that spot,



plummeting faster and faster until you finally, smoothly glide to a halt in the sky above it.

At that point, you must wait a moment or two as Google Earth downloads and displays the details of your location. It doesn't store all this data on your computer, instead fetching it as needed from Google's own computers.

Once you land, you can start to ladle on the data Google has archived. This is what makes Google Earth more than a nifty replacement for a globe: You can take the measure of a place in many ways, combining the sources of data offered in Google Earth's "Layers" toolbar.

With a few clicks, for example, you can produce a map that illustrates which Metro stops offer the best access to both pizza and ATMs. You can plot out nearby churches and coffee shops, add clickable buttons that display crime rates for the year 2000, and inspect outlines of school district, Zip code and congressional district boundaries.

One of Google Earth's most useful features is the "Measure" command. It calculates distances between points A and B, whether by a straight line or along the path of your choice.

You can add "placemarks" for any interesting spots you find, then share them with other Google Earth users via an online bulletin board. Users of Google Earth have accumulated a massive library of shared placemarks that span a wide range of geo-trivia. One individual, for example, has assembled a set of placemarks that point to historic lighthouses; another is mapping the locations of publicly accessible webcams.

And yet this free program is still one of the most useful free downloads I've seen in a while. It should make other mapping-software competitors nervous.

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